

GAME ON The Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad

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ALL SET FOR THE BIG BASH

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The usually tranquil offices in the premises of the Gujarat Cricket Association (GCA)—which manages the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad—are abuzz with activity. If an International Cricket Council (ICC) team had visited the stadium a few weeks ago, the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) president Roger Binny was here in mid-September while his team continues to camp in the city to oversee preparations for the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup.

The 2023 edition of the quadrennial One Day International (ODI) extravaganza—delayed this time due to the Covid-19 pandemic—will kick off with the opening ceremony at the Narendra Modi Stadium on October 4. Besides the inaugural match the following day and the final on November 19, the 132,000-seater facility—the largest cricket stadium in the world—will be hosting three more ties. The most anticipated India-Pakistan clash on October 14 is among them.

Built on the same site as the erstwhile Sardar Patel Stadium, the new facility—named after the Indian prime minister—was inaugurated in 2021. It has already hosted several high-octane matches, including the Indian Premier League (IPL) finals in 2022 and 2023. But hosting half a dozen World Cup matches, admit GCA officials, is a different ball game.

The pitch is in "mint condition", but special attention has been paid to the outfield. A wet outfield had delayed play in a rain-marred IPL final in May this year, inviting much criticism. So, following a spell of heavy showers in September third week, the GCA is taking "special care", with a dedicated agricultural engineer on duty.

Among the ICC's recommendations, say sources, was to make the stadium more accessible to differently-abled cricket fans, on par with international standards. All renovations have been completed, with more seating capacity in the media box and a new commentary box to facilitate those covering the proceedings. While the parking capacity has been increased too, direct access to the Metro station from one of the exit gates is expected to ease the rush of fans. ■

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